

DISSERTATION NOTES BY CRIMINOGENIC RISK FACTOR

Emerging Adults (18-26) in Residential/Correctional Settings

SECTION 1: TRAUMA & ACEs

Prevalence in Justice-Involved Youth:

- Justice-involved young people experience an average of **3 ACEs prior to their first arrest**, necessitating trauma-informed practice (Rice et al., 2023)
- ACEs can have an additive effect, with each additional event conferring an increased risk for a range of mental disorders, alcohol and other drug misuse, criminal activity, and subsequent recidivism

Trauma-Informed Care:

- **SHARE** is a trauma-informed care recommendation for justice-involved young people (page 262 of Rice et al.)
- Trauma symptoms include: psychological distress, externalizing disorders directly linked to offending, internalizing disorders indirectly contribute by reducing access to protective factors

Treatment Implications:

- Following contact with the justice system, young people have an elevated risk of dying by suicide or drug overdose
- Justice-involved young people are less likely to engage with mental health services than young people who are not justice-involved
- Community-based mental health services can have meaningful impact on justice-involved youth without adopting explicit forensic orientation

SECTION 2: SUBSTANCE DEPENDENCE

Prevalence Statistics:

- **78.4%** of all teens who have contact with the juvenile justice system tested positive for drugs, were under the influence when they committed their offense, or admitted substance use/addiction
- **Only 3.6%** of juvenile offenders receive some form of substance use/abuse treatment (Denny & Connor, 2016)
- Mitchell et al. found that **88%** of incarcerated individuals had a substance use problem, and **98%** had at least one diagnosed mental condition related to substance use

Substance Use & Recidivism:

- Substance use increases the possibility of reoffending after release, even among those who do not fit criteria for substance use disorders
- Two-year reconviction rates for drug-related offenses range from **18% to 55%**
- Individuals with substance use histories have significantly higher recidivism tendency for violent crimes
- Post-release substance usage associated with problems in social reintegration, raising probability of recidivism

Self-Medication Theory:

- People do not take substances for recreational purposes, but rather to cope with underlying psychological distress
- People who have experienced trauma, psychological disorders, or ongoing stresses are more prone to turn to substance use as a coping strategy
- Recidivism among people with substance use history is caused by unresolved psychological distress and social disadvantages that prolong reoffending cycles

Emerging Adult Specifics:

- Engaging in drug use early has been referred to as the 'drug use career' — extends throughout entire life course
- Emerging adulthood (18-25) is when pivotal decisions are made whether to desist from or persist in substance use
- Life circumstances such as marriage and employment influence desistance from substance use

SECTION 3: UNEMPLOYMENT & ECONOMIC INSTABILITY**Impact on Recidivism:**

- Justice involvement is strong predictor of school dropout, unemployment, low earnings, welfare dependence in young adulthood
- Economic instability was related to both low-level offending and drug use, with higher levels of economic instability predicting higher expected counts of both behaviors
- Those who worked more hours had lower levels of offending

Emerging Adult Challenges:

- Vocational outcomes for emerging adults with mental health conditions are poorer than emerging adults without mental health conditions AND more mature adults with mental health conditions
- Higher levels of education were found to increase both low-level offending and low-level drug use in emerging adults
- Education interacts differently for those in emerging adulthood due to prolonged adolescence, increased college attendance, and decreased informal social controls

Turning Points:

- Life circumstances such as marriage and employment have been shown to influence desistance
- Prolonged adolescent offenders engage in crime because of failure to achieve adult status symbolized by stable employment
- Hours worked per week were significant predictor of low-level offending (more hours = lower offending)

SECTION 4: ANTISOCIAL PEERS & DELINQUENT ASSOCIATES

Social Learning Theory:

- Peers are the most important social influence for a person between late childhood and early adulthood
- Individuals learn criminal behavior through exposure, modeling, and reinforcement within social contexts
- What is learned includes not only techniques but also motives, drives, rationalizations, and attitudes
- Criminal behavior occurs when definitions favorable to crime outnumber definitions unfavorable to crime

Peer Influence on Recidivism:

- Peer pressure, network centrality, and delinquent enmeshment are established causes of developing delinquent peers
- Youth who experience family conflict are far more likely to associate with delinquent peers later
- Delinquent peers and family conflict share a feedback loop
- Gang membership and mental health decline are reinforcing processes

Differential Association:

- Differential associations vary in: frequency, duration, priority, and intensity
- Associations early in life (priority), lasting longer (duration), happening more often (frequency), or involving emotionally significant relationships (intensity) are more influential
- Crime is transmitted across social networks and generations

SECTION 5: FAMILY DYSFUNCTION & CONFLICT

Impact on Offending:

- Children with high levels of family conflict offend earlier, more frequently and severely, and continue offending into young adulthood
- Family conflict cited by factors such as incarceration, symptoms of problematic internalizing and externalizing behavior, and family turmoil
- Family conflict creates negative mental health outcomes during reentry, interrupts family processes, and places individuals at risk for reoffending

Protective Effects of Family Support:

- **Emotional support delays time to recidivism and reduces probability by around 19%**
- Those with greater levels of post-release family emotional support were considerably less likely to reoffend
- Preserving positive family identity (considering oneself a 'family man') associated with lower likelihood of reoffending
- Family support promotes pro-social identity and serves as buffer against psychological strain

Parental Factors:

- Parental criminality and living in socially poor neighborhood were found to be important predictors of juvenile reoffending
- Parental attachment predicts reduction in low-level offending

- High-risk people had greater rates of drug issues and were more likely to originate from single-parent families or non-traditional family structures

SECTION 6: INSTITUTIONALIZATION & SYSTEM EFFECTS

Negative Effects of Confinement:

- **85% of adolescents placed into residential treatment will be reincarcerated within 5 years** (Mowen et al., 2018)
- Incarceration often fails to deter juvenile delinquency and presents further challenges
- Those sent to prison had higher recidivism rates than those placed on probation
- Placing people in custody tends to make them more likely to reoffend

Reentry Challenges:

- Period immediately following release (reentry) presents tremendous challenges including creating post-incarceration identities and reestablishing ties
- Justice involvement is strong predictor of school dropout, unemployment, low earnings, welfare dependence
- Following contact with justice system, young people have elevated risk of dying by suicide or drug overdose

What Doesn't Work:

- Boot camps, scared straight programs, intensive supervision have weak, null, or iatrogenic effects
- Scared straight consistently makes recidivism worse
- Some 'tough' programs actually made crime worse
- Prison doesn't rehabilitate much, sometimes harms

SECTION 7: TREATMENT RESISTANCE & ENGAGEMENT

Barriers to Treatment:

- Justice-involved young people are less likely to engage with mental health services than young people who are not justice-involved
- Justice-involved people often approach intervention with lack of motivation, argumentative behavior, impulsivity, and skepticism
- Psychological barriers like low motivation or denial decrease engagement even when services available
- People who do not take responsibility for behavior are less motivated to change and have higher risk of dropping out

Dropout Rates:

- In MST-EA feasibility study: 41 participants enrolled, only 21 fully finished (51% completion)
- MI has been shown to reduce dropout rates compared to interventions without MI
- Unmet psychological needs during reentry increase reoffending risk

Solutions - Motivational Interviewing:

- MI appears effective for managing resistance by avoiding confrontation and promoting opportunities to enhance intrinsic motivation
- MI is collaborative communication approach designed to strengthen motivation and commitment to specific goal
- Results: MI significantly more effective in reducing recidivism rates and increasing session attendance
- MI showed greater effectiveness among those with low readiness to change and in early stages of change

RESEARCH GAPS TO ADDRESS

Specific to Emerging Adults:

- There are really no established interventions with evidence of efficacy to reduce recidivism specifically among emerging adults
- All current approaches have moderate effects, but efficacy specifically with emerging adults is either unknown or less potent
- Recidivism reduction approaches for emerging adults should include provision of good mental health care AND approaches that address changing nature of recidivism correlates during transition from adolescence to mature adulthood

Program Development Needs:

- Lack of developmentally informed, evidence-based desistance programs for 18-26 year olds in corrections
- Limited integration of CBT + Schema therapy in correctional settings
- Insufficient trauma-informed approaches specifically tailored for young adults
- Need for community-based models that prevent re-offending while providing services in least restrictive environment